



On Second Thought

By WILLIE KLEIN

Nelson King pitching again—Browns and bonds

A note reached this department that Nelson King, former partner of Roy Face in the Pittsburgh Pirates' bull pen, will pitch for the East Orange Browns Tuesday night against the Soverels in an Essex County League game at Grove St. Oval.

The first thought was why did King drop out of baseball and what has happened to him since?

After quick tracking, King was on the other end of the telephone conversation, in Chatham, where he moved nearly a year ago with his wife, their daughter, Laurie, 2. Nelson does his pitching now—in addition to the Browns—as a municipal bond salesman for John J. Ryan, one of Newark's red-hot sports fans.

"Know any rich people I can try to interest in tax-exempt bonds," King kidded.

We referred him to Walter O'Malley and Del Webb, with whom we are on a Christmas card exchange basis. We consider this a rather close friendship even if their secretaries sign the cards.

After fending off a proposition to invest in a Perth Amboy project, "assuming you're in the 50 per cent bracket," we grounded King and switched him to the Pirates.

"I guess I had the standard reason for quitting," the tall sidecarner said. "Arm trouble. I hurt it the last week of June, 1956, against the Cubs. After that it was all downhill. Took me nine years to reach the majors and then I was out—at 31—quicker than you flip your electric switch."

On threshold of brilliant relief career

The Pirates shipped Nelson to Johns Hopkins where doctors found he had torn tricep muscles. The healing process, he was told, would be slow.

"It sure was," King continued. "I was practically useless the rest of the season. The Pirates showed great patience carrying me the next year. I did next to nothing for them. When they sent me to Columbus in the International that winter I decided it was time to stop fooling myself and quit. Anyway, it was time to look for a more lasting job. Al Rosen of the Indians did it. Why not me?"

For a while Nelson appeared on the verge of a brilliant relief career with the Pirates. He was the earned-run leader at the time of his injury and received emergency calls as frequently as Face.

"I thought I was finally set," King recalled. "The breaks were in my favor. I went to training in good shape and got my chance when fellows the Pirates were counting on pulled up lame. I didn't give a run in 26 exhibition innings and I was in. But pow—that one pitch against the Cubs and good-bye career."

The conversation drifted to Face and we asked what Roy had done to improve to his present lofty status.

"Roy was just as good two years ago and last year," King replied. "He's the first to admit it. Things are going right for him. He's getting all the breaks. Stack breaks with a standout relief pitcher and you get the great record he owns."

Face plays solitaire during game

"Roy has everything a reliever needs," King added. "His fork ball is murder as a change with his fast one and he has pin-point control. One more big item in his favor is a perfect temperament. He doesn't quiver a nerve when he walks into any tough situation. He's as placid as Hank Aaron. Nothing frightens either one."

"Since Roy doesn't get into a game until the late innings he remains in the clubhouse playing solitaire. The radio keeps him posted. Then about the fifth he goes to the bullpen. Sounds like a nice easy job, and it is, but this fellow is a wonder. Roy is also a hillbilly fan and plays a mean guitar," King said.

Our bond salesman had an explanation for Bob Friend's difficulties this year.

"He had the big year like Bob Turley and got to spring camp overweight. Friend needs lots of work to be sharp and he didn't get it. Bad weather, sniffles, etc. So when the season started he wasn't sharp and he pressed too much. That can be disastrous. One top of it all, Friend is also the world's greatest worrier. Put them all together and it adds up to the rough time he had. He's in shape the last two months, however, but now he isn't getting runs."

How did King get mixed up in the Essex County League?

"My brother-in-law, Walter Earl, talked me into it," he explained. "Walt's catcher for the Browns and he has been after me a long time. I finally gave in. I guess you could call us the first brother-in-law battery in baseball. And the Essex League is surprisingly good. I don't say that as an alibi if I get slugged Tuesday. But you probably knew it's a strong league."

King recalls he was released twice in his first year, '46, "and maybe I should have taken the hint." He flunked in trials with Cards and Red Sox farms. After that he saw New Iberia, La.; Geneva, Ala.; York, Pa.; Charleston, S.C. and other points before landing with Denver in '53 under Andy Cohen. Used in relief Nelson had a 15-3 record, saved 15 more and turned in a 2.01 ERA.

"That winter the Pirates bought me," King said. "I read it in the papers while on my honeymoon." But he stayed briefly in '54, flashing with New Orleans under Danny Murtagh with a 16-5 record and top ERA. He was with the Pirates for three months in '55 before arm trouble struck and he got a ticket to Hollywood.

His pick for the N.L. flag?
"The Braves because they've been through this thing before," King said.